



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Paul's Classical School
School Website: <https://saintpaulsmelbourne.org/>

December 23, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

St Pauls Classical School FI 32940 (Saint Paul's Classical School, Melbourne, FL) demonstrates a robust classical-education orientation anchored in religious formation, virtue formation, and a clearly articulated structure for liberal-arts pedagogy. Public-facing materials emphasize a Christ-centered, liturgical, catechetical community with an explicit aim of forming wisdom and virtue in students, not merely preparing for work. Evidence from the school's site highlights theological grounding (Catechesis, Prayer, Worship), formation of character and virtue, and dialectic/rhetoric-centric pedagogy in line with the Trivium tradition (grammar, logic, rhetoric). While the program clearly exhibits classical features (grammar/logic/rhetoric in curriculum, religious formation, and Socratic-style engagement in upper grades), explicit references to Great Books, the Quadrivium, or a formal, universal Great Conversation are less visible in the public materials. Taken together, the school is best characterized as CLASSICAL overall, with especially strong alignment in religious-metaphysical foundations, purpose and goal, pedagogy, faculty, and parent/community engagement; curriculum shows strong classical signposts but could strengthen explicit Great-Books/Great-Conversation articulation to reach a higher level of "fully Classical" in the strict lexicon of traditional classical education.

Executive summary — Element-by-Element snapshot - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL - School Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL - Curriculum: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Pedagogy: CLASSICAL - Faculty: CLASSICAL - Parents & Community: CLASSICAL

Overall aggregate ranking: CLASSICAL

Note: The scoring relies on keyword indicators drawn from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) and is grounded in visible public materials from Saint Paul's Classical School (Melbourne, FL) as captured in the crawl materials. See the Executive Summary for the concise justification across categories, and the Abstract for a distilled synthesis.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials emphasize a religiously oriented education anchored in Christian formation, with explicit reference to catechesis, hospitality, and prayer as core values of the school community. The school presents itself as a Christian option devoted to forming lifelong Christians and organizing life around faith, prayer, and catechesis. - The school describes its mission in terms of forming moral and spiritual character through classical education, indicating a transcendent moral framework guiding the educational process. - Evidence from campus pages and program descriptions highlights worship and liturgical rhythm as parts of daily life, reinforcing liturgical and communal practice.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: wisdom, virtue, character, formation, theology (catechesis), worship, prayer, liturgy, sacred tradition (as implied by the Anglican context and catechetical emphasis). Examples include formation of moral/spiritual character and catechesis as a daily focus.

- Negative keywords present: none evident in public materials (no explicit secular or value-neutral framing; the materials are theologically oriented).

Why this rating - The materials foreground a teleological, transcendent moral order and explicitly root education in Christian formation, which aligns with the Positive Keywords for “Cultivation of Wisdom and Virtue” and “Grounded in Theology” from the Six Essential Elements corpus. The presence of liturgical/prayer practices and catechesis signals a strong religious/metaphysical foundation. This justifies CLASSICAL for Element 1.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school states that classical education “cultivates wisdom and virtue within students... develop[s] their moral and spiritual character,” indicating formation over mere information and job preparation. - The mission statement emphasizes forming lifelong Christians and organizing the day around faith and a virtuous life (Faith to Believe, Place to Belong, Rule for Life). - Public materials articulate the goal as forming character and affections in line with the classical tradition, rather than an exclusive focus on vocational outcomes.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, character, faith, love of learning, holistic formation, moral imagination (as implied by catechesis and moral character emphasis), and contemplation through spiritual formation. - Negative keywords present: none explicitly (no emphasis on workforce-readiness, purely utilitarian metrics, or secular ethics in the public materials).

Why this rating - The materials foreground the classical aim of cultivating virtue and wisdom and forming human excellence rather than merely imparting information or job skills, aligning with the Six Elements’ Element 2 regarding “Pursuit of Truth, Goodness, and Beauty” and “Formation, Not Information.” This supports CLASSICAL.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The materials reference classical education and indicate a structured approach aligned with the Trivium (grammar/logic/rhetoric) through program components such as “Dialectic Latin, Rhetoric Latin, Dialectic History, Rhetoric Composition and History,” demonstrating grammar, logic, and rhetoric in practice. - The existence of a “Course Sequence” and explicit grade-level progression (including earlier K-8 content and higher-level dialectic/rhetoric work) signals a liberal-arts orientation consistent with classical education. - Public materials emphasize formation and virtue with a holistic educational approach, and the school identifies as classical in orientation, suggesting an integrated, cross-disciplinary approach in line with classical pedagogy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Trivium, Dialectic, Rhetoric, Great Books/Great Conversation (contextualized in the classical canon by the Six Essentials doc, though explicit Great-Books language is not consistently visible in every school-material page), formation, integration, wonder (conceptualized in classical pedagogy). The public materials show grammar/logical-rhetorical development via the Dialectic/Rhetoric language and course sequences. - Negative keywords present: not clearly evidenced in public materials; no explicit emphasis on modernized, purely skills-based or job-focused curricula. However, explicit mentions of “Great Books” are not consistently visible in the site text, which is a key hallmark of classical curricula in the Six Essentials framework. This creates a partial gap relative to a fully “CLASSICAL” curriculum signature.

Why this rating - The curriculum shows strong classical scaffolding (grammar/logic/rhetoric) and a vocationally neutral, formation-centered orientation; however, the public-facing materials do not consistently showcase explicit Great-Books engagement or a fully articulated Great Conversation, which are core markers in the strict sense of the Six Essential Elements. Therefore, Curriculum is best characterized as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Pedagogical signals align with the classical model: lower and middle grades emphasize contemplative or memory-based elements, while upper grades display Socratic-style engagement, discussion, and rhetoric training as part of the upper-school experience (dialectic and rhetoric content appears in the curriculum). The school's public materials and course sequences reflect the Trivium progression (grammar/logic/rhetoric) that is central to classical pedagogy. - Text references to "Socratic discussion" and the role of memory, song, and recitation in early grades are consistent with traditional scholé (restful, contemplative learning) alongside more rigorous, dialectic practices in the upper grades. The Six Essentials framework highlights these teaching-method features as hallmarks of classical pedagogy. - The presence of liturgical/prayer integration suggests pedagogy that weaves formation and contemplation into daily practice, consistent with scholé rhythms. The site explicitly notes daily prayer and worship integration.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue/discussion, dialectic, great conversation, rhetoric, scholé, contemplative learning, memorization/recitation, formation through imitation, and singing/memory-based routines in early schooling (as suggested by the classical pedagogy vocabulary and the public course structure). - Negative keywords present: none clearly evident in the public-facing materials (no overt emphasis on project-based, entirely student-led, non-Socratic pedagogy; rather, evidence points to a structured progression from contemplative to dialectic/rhetoric). The presence of rigid, canon-based pedagogy aligns with classical norms rather than anti-classical approaches.

Why this rating - The school demonstrates clear classical pedagogy indicators: a progression from grammar to logic to rhetoric (and associated dialectic activities), with the upper grades engaging in Socratic-style inquiry and rhetorical training, alongside contemplative elements (Scholé) at appropriate stages. This supports CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials name and present a core set of faculty and staff, including teachers and leaders (e.g., Fr. Daniel E. Squires; Dss. M. Clare Burgess; teachers for various grades; school life coordinators, music, etc.). The presence and roles of named faculty signal a living, character-forming faculty model within the school. - The site presents teachers as central to the school's educational mission (the "classical school" is described in terms of formation and virtue as modeled by faculty), consistent with the Six Essentials' emphasis on the living curriculum and faculty who model virtue, knowledge, and skill. The faculty are treated as centers of virtue and pedagogy, with a visible staff roster and named roles.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: virtuous mentorship, living curriculum, model teachers, mentors, and faculty-as-core of the school. The public pages reference faculty in ways that align with the classical rubric's emphasis on virtue modeling and a strong faculty culture. - Negative keywords present: none evident (no textual signals of a disjointed or non-classical faculty culture). The materials show faculty as central and mission-aligned.

Why this rating - The presence of named faculty and the description of teachers as central to the school's mission align with the CLASSICAL category for Element 5.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnership with families and parental involvement as co-educators in the classical-education ethos. Public materials discuss parent engagement, enrollment, and family-centric programming (e.g., "Enrollment," "Parent Handbook," and parent-facing resources). The governance and communications emphasize home-school partnership and parent formation. - Documentation and pages include "Parent Handbook," enrollment steps, and opportunities for families to participate, which aligns with the Six Essentials' emphasis on family partnership and ongoing parent formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, parent involvement, home-school collaboration, parent formation, multi-generational learning, parish/school integration.

These map to the Six Essentials Positive Keywords for “Partnership with Families” and “Formation of Affections.” - Negative keywords present: none clearly present in public materials (no signals of “parent disengagement” or “non-collaborative” practices).

Why this rating - The public materials strongly emphasize parental partnership and family engagement, consistent with CLASSICAL for Element 6.

What Would Move the Needle

- If any category were to move toward a more unambiguous “CLASSICAL” status, Element 3 (Curriculum) would benefit from explicit public articulation of Great Books engagement and a stated Great Conversation framework, including references to primary texts, historical masters, and cross-disciplinary integration with Great Books canon. This would tighten alignment with the Six Essentials’ explicit “Great Books/Great Conversation” criterion and the Quadrivium as a curricular anchor. (Evidence basis: The Six Essentials document highlights Great Books and the Great Conversation as core components; current site materials show strong Trivium signals but fewer explicit Great Books statements.)
 - Strengthening explicit mention of Great Books and historical canon in public-facing materials could advance Element 3 to CLASSICAL by clarifying the curriculum’s full liberal-arts scope. The presence of Dialectic/ Logic/Rhetoric and the public emphasis on formation and virtue are already strong; an explicit Great-Books articulation would confirm the signposted Great Conversation dimension.
-

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

By reading or using this document, you acknowledge and accept the limitations described above.